



# **YouTube Family Vlogging as a Promoter of Digital Child Labour: A Case Study on ‘The Bucket List Family’**

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# Abstract

Over the past decade, there has been a considerable rise in popularity of family vlog channels on YouTube. However, these videos have been receiving growing criticism for hosting the children as the main ‘stars’. With YouTube being the main source of income for some of these family units, concerns rise regarding the possibility of family vlogging accommodating a new type of child labour. For this reason, it is crucial to understand how the children’s rights might be threatened. At the same time, research within this field is still limited as family vlogging concerns a fairly recent phenomenon. Accordingly, the current thesis aims to fill these research gaps by contextualizing the practices of family vlogging through a rights-based approach. To do so, a case study was conducted on a YouTube account named ‘The Bucket List Family’. Using content analysis, 5 of their videos were analysed qualitatively and 100 of their video titles were analysed quantitatively. Findings confirm that the children played a central role in contributing to the popularity of the videos. Moreover, the children’s images were consistently and successfully used to further capitalize the family’s brand. Therefore, one can conclude that these children are being exposed to digital child labour, which can mean a possible breach of their rights. The considerable exposure of the children in the videos not only robs them from their privacy, but it also does so without their explicit consent, leaving them extremely vulnerable. As such, the conclusions of this thesis implicate that more research in this field is needed, so that future policymaking can be guided towards a better protection of the children. Additionally, by exposing the digital child labour practices behind family vlogging, this study hopes to bring more societal awareness to the topic.

**Keywords:** YouTube, Family Vlogging, Digital Child Labour, Exploitation, Children’s Rights, Attention Economy, Privacy, Digital Footprints, Surveillance

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*Saudade.*

# Introduction

According to YouTube, there are “500+ hours of content uploaded every minute” (YouTube, n.d.-b). A part of this content is produced by so called ‘family vloggers’, that record their daily lives and the lives of their families, including their children, and share them with anyone who wants to keep up with them. However, these videos have attracted a lot of attention for hosting children, most of the times minors, as their main ‘stars’, melting the hearts of their audience on one side, and infuriating the general public on the other. With YouTube openly being the main source of income for some of these family units, concerns rise regarding the possibility of these children being involved in a new type of child labour. For this reason, it is crucial to understand how children are being used for YouTube popularity and how their rights might be threatened. Accordingly, the current thesis aims to contextualize these practices by using a rights-based approach. Hence, to reach this goal, the following research questions are established:

RQ 1: How and to what extent are YouTube family vloggers using their children as labour for the ‘family business’?

RQ 2: How can these new practices be analysed in the light of children’s rights?

In order to obtain the answers to these questions and gather comprehensive knowledge on this topic, a case study approach was decided upon. Using both qualitative and quantitative approaches, a content analysis was conducted on ‘The Bucket List Family’. Their YouTube channel portrays a relevant example of what family vlogging consists of. By analysing this phenomenon, the current research presents important scientific and societal contributions. Not only does it provide the field of Media and Communication studies with deeper insight on this topic, but it also brings awareness to an ever-growing practice. By laying these foundations, this research might simultaneously act as a guiding compass for society to navigate this complex digital world.

Likewise, the current thesis will follow the coming structure. In the first chapter, the phenomenon of family vlogging will be contextualized. This will be done by scrutinizing the platform where it takes place (YouTube), by explaining the concept of vlog, by

introducing the family chosen for the case study and by providing knowledge on the current legal framework around this practice. The second chapter will position this research within the academic field, by understanding what has already been done regarding the topic of analysis. Additionally, the third chapter will present the theoretical foundations that help build this research. In chapter four, methodology is presented and justified. The following chapter, presents the results obtained and further analyses them. Finally, conclusions are drawn, limitations are discussed and future approaches suggested.

# **1. Contextualizing Family Vlogging**

## **1.1 YouTube**

YouTube is a video sharing website that was created in 2005 by three former PayPal employees - Jawed Karim, Steve Chen and Chad Hurley- nevertheless, it can be conceptualized in multiple ways. The platform works as a digital library, where videos are uploaded, stored and ready for viewing. Users can explore this database by using keywords to find and access the items they are looking for, as the platform works simultaneously as a search engine. According to Forbes, with 3 billion searches per month, YouTube is actually the second largest search engine in the world, right after the giant Google (Wagner, 2017, p. 56). In fact, it can be argued that YouTube is the biggest video sharing platform in the world (Ceci, 2022). Moreover, the ability to like, comment and share videos turns YouTube into a powerful social media platform as well. Ultimately, the website's collaborative nature, where users can not only shape what they produce but also what they consume, implies that YouTube can also be conceptualized as a creative hub. However, despite gathering content, YouTube is not a content producer per se (Burgess & Green, 2009). Indeed, "as patron, YouTube provides the supporting and constraining mechanisms of a system whose meaning is generated by the uses to which it is put and within which, collectively, users exercise agency" (Burgess & Green, 2008, p. 2).

Once a venue to spontaneously share amateur content, YouTube is now a key figure in an industry of content production that eventually introduced new professional occupations. To understand this transition, one needs to look back into the media company's history. In December of 2007, after a couple of years of trials for advertisement within the platform, YouTube launched the 'YouTube Partner Program', allowing channels that met specific requirements to earn money from advertisement on their videos. This possibility for revenue revolutionized the platform and encouraged content creation. The next year, another important step towards the professionalization of content creators was taken, the creation of 'YouTube Insight', now known as 'YouTube Analytics'. The tool provides creators with important metrics on the performance of their channels and videos and allows them to get precious data on their audience, like location, gender, and age. With monetization possibilities attracting a considerable number of new users to the platform, and in an attempt to further stimulate content development, YouTube decided to dedicate an entire section to its creators, the 'Creators Hub' – "offering assistance to creators regarding content planning and audience management, including specific rules and guidelines for acceptable content" (García-Rapp, 2017, p. 232). In the years that followed, YouTube implemented multiple advertisement formats, like Google's 'AdSense' and the possibility to create sponsored videos, shaping the platform into the "advertising powerhouse" (Geider, 2021, p. 4) that we currently know and turning YouTube into the main occupation and source of income for a lot of users. According to Stauff, "a popular YouTuber could be making anywhere between \$3,000 and \$10,000 per one million views" (2020, p. 5). YouTube revenue can be divided into five different categories of origin: "advertisement, affiliate marketing, sponsorship, donations and merchandise" (Sabatier, 2022, How do Youtubers Make Money section). Currently, two main types of content coexist within YouTube, amateur and professional. However, "user-generated content on social media platforms has also become a modern form of entertainment" (Geider, 2021, p. 4), making the line between amateur and professional content gradually harder to distinguish. This growth on the popularity of amateur content, can be argued to be linked with the success of the 'reality tv' format. This format follows real-life situations and broadcasts unscripted narratives and has attracted major attention from the public through its different sub-genres. One genre that seems to have particularly grown during the last decade is 'lifestyle reality tv'. A perfect example of this, is the show "Keeping Up with the Kardashians". Created in 2007, the production follows the everyday adventures of the Kardashian-Jenner family and is

amongst the longest-running tv shows in the United States. At the time, the show's success revealed the audience's desire for a merge between anonymous relatable content and professional production, which inspired content producers across various platforms. On YouTube, this trend became visible through the emergence of the 'vlog'.

## 1.2 Vlog

Vlog is a new video production trend, defined by Talukdar as “a video log, which could include any kind of content” (2020, p. 749). Likewise, a vlog can be considered as a visual journal entry. Individuals keep track of their lives by recording themselves and others around them. Uploads can be spontaneous or have a pre-defined schedule that can range from daily, weekly or even monthly uploads. Moreover, in Burgess and Green's perspective, a vlog can also be characterized as a “conversational form that is somewhat emblematic of YouTube's user-created content” (2009, p. 43). This conversational tone of vlogs is essential to create and strengthen a relation with viewers, as it builds trust and intimacy between the creator and them.

Vlogging genres are not always easy to define, however, the book “*YouTube Vlogging: The Complete Manual*” places them into seven categories: “personal, humour, fashion and beauty, travel, science and education, news and commentary and experimental” (2015, pp. 14-15). Even if notably different, all these videos have one common characteristic, their creators share a considerable amount of personal information through them (de Zeeuw, 2018). Amongst these videos, there is one category particularly known for the amount of personal information it contains, family vlogs. Family vlogs consist of recording, editing and subsequent sharing of family-related content. The highly personal videos portray the everyday life of regular families, and often contain footage of children, including minors. In some cases, intimacy reaches other levels, as some parents go as far as sharing the birth of their children. Family vlogs can be frequently associated with homemade videos, made for future memories for the family. However, it is “the ability to reach a large audience—and subsequently, the ability to monetize that reach” (Riggio, 2021, p. 508) that distinguishes the two of them. This monetization is only possible through a powerful combination of the number of viewers and the number of subscribers. Even if revenue comes directly from the number of people that watch a particular video, having a loyal audience creates a long-lasting safety net for vloggers, as it guarantees a

minimum of views. Seemingly mere numbers, views and subscribers are extremely important for YouTubers, as they “not only display but also actively perform – in terms of influencing – online value” (García-Rapp, 2017, p. 234). Hence, since YouTube careers are often “constituted around highly publicised social media performances of parenting and family life” (Pers, n.d., who are mommy vloggers section) and they embody the main source of income for some families, these digital indicators become a priority for family vloggers.

### **1.3 The Bucket List Family**

With the current thesis aiming to extensively analyse the realm of YouTube’s family vloggers, it is of crucial importance to limit the sample by focusing on a specific case. Therefore, and for this effect, the author chose to analyse a channel named ‘The Bucket List Family’. The Gee family – commonly known as ‘The Bucket List Family’ – consists of dad Garret, mom Jessica and their children: Dorothy (9 years old), Manilla (7 years old) and Calihan (4 years old). The videos posted on their channel revolve around the family’s journey as ‘family travel journalists’, as they call themselves, and documents their everyday life as full-time travellers.

‘The Bucket List Family’s YouTube and Instagram paths began the 15<sup>th</sup> of August 2015, after dad Garret sold his iPhone app to the social media giant Snapchat. After the transaction was concluded, the family decided to sell everything and start travelling the world. While planning to become full-time travellers, the family set up a list of goals to guide their journey (see figure 1). One of the goals, “live a life of service and compassion” (quote) invokes the family’s devotion to the Church of Jesus Christ of Latter-day Saints (commonly known as Mormonism). This devotion has been made public by the family, as Garret and Jessica describe how they first met when they were both missionaries for the church in Russia, back in 2009. Jessica even provides the link to the church’s website in the preface she writes about herself.



Figure 1: List of goals set by the family before starting their journey

Source: The Bucket List Family (n.d.-a)

The premise behind the family's project to travel the world is the notion of 'Bucket list', "a set of meaningful goals that a person hopes to achieve before they die" (Chu et al., 2018, p. 151), which is simultaneously the name of their YouTube channel. This channel, currently has a staggering 1.4 million subscribers and already includes about 340 videos. When the family begun their adventure, only the two older kids were born - Dorothy was 2 years old, and Manilla had not even turned 1 year yet. Almost seven years later the family of five is still travelling and even though they bought a permanent house in Hawaii they don't seem to be slowing down any time soon. Despite already profiting from a great amount of money through their YouTube channel, the family decided to further expand their 'business' and has now multiple sources of revenue that include merchandise, a monthly subscription club on their website, an ongoing cartoon show project and multiple brand partnerships. By analysing their website, one can clearly realise that for the Gee family this is "not merely a hobby or a supplementary income but an established career with its own ecology and economy" (Abidin, 2017, p. 1) as they provide visitors of their website – that counts with 198.000 visitors per month (The Bucket List Family, n.d.-c) – with a business-like approach in their section 'Media Kit'. Here, visitors can find data on the family's social media presence, on the characteristics of their audience and on their commercial achievements – like their highly profitable continued partnership with GoPro

for whom they allege they “generated over \$135k in sales (...) in 30 days” (The Bucket List Family, n.d.-c, top partnerships section). The family even goes a step further by incorporating a section named ‘The Bucket List Brand’, giving a clear indication that the family unit simultaneously serves business purposes. Additionally, all three kids, and all of them minors, have personal Instagram accounts and YouTube channels managed by their parents, which shows that all members of the family contribute to the ‘family business’. As summarised by Blum-Ross and Livingstone, “being a blogger imposes further demands—to represent oneself authentically, to meet the professional standards of the blogging community, and to develop a commercial strategy of maximising audiences and revenues from one’s blog” (Blum-Ross & Livingstone, 2017, p. 112), and the Bucket List Family seems to be following these demands promptly.



Figure 2: The Gee family, also known as 'The Bucket List Family'

Source: The Bucket List Family (2021, October 1)

## 1.4 Legal Framework

Family vlogging implies that all members of the family take part in the content created, which in most cases means that minors are featured, just as it happens in the ‘Bucket List Family’s videos. With this new trend gaining popularity, debates arise regarding the child’s best interest and regarding ethical, financial and legal concerns. What is more, “social media production involving children is a relatively new phenomenon and operates



somewhat differently from the use of children in the traditional entertainment industry” (Geider, 2021, p. 15) which further complicates possible regulations to the activity.

Currently, in the United States – home to one of the world’s biggest entertainment industries, Hollywood – most states require children involved in the industry to have a work permit. Working hours are controlled and the child’s earnings are secured by the California Child Actor’s Bill (commonly known as the Coogan Law) (Geider, 2021). This law ensures that children working in entertainment positions will have their earnings, or a part of them, retained until they are legally adults and can manage them themselves (SAG-AFTRA, n.d.). This legislation emerged as a mechanism to prevent parents from taking financial advantage of their minor children as it has been so frequently reported in Hollywood. Similarly, according to the law, in the United Kingdom children “should not perform for more than six consecutive days, and children aged five to nine should not perform continuously for more than 2.5 hours a day” (Tait, 2015). Nevertheless, what these two examples have in common is the fact that they cannot be applied to the social media sphere, particularly when parents are the ones responsible for the content, as there is “a tradition of family autonomy immune from invasive state interference in the upbringing of one’s child” (Masterson, 2018, p. 597). The main reason for family vlogging being so hard to regulate is because most of the footage is filmed at home with a seemingly spontaneous nature, making it simple for family vlogging to “easily disguise itself as an entirely voluntary, informal, and unorganized way for parents to showcase to the world the harmless fun they have with their children” (Riggio, 2021, p. 511).

On the other hand, there is one country that is actively trying to regulate this digital labour, France. The nation’s president just recently officially passed a new law that regulates the “commercial use of images of children under 16 years old on online platforms” (Boring, 2020). This new law comes into place to fill the gap between digital entertainment and the already regulated traditional one and makes it mandatory for parents to request official approval before they can include their children in online projects that can be considered as labour (Boring, 2020), as is the case of family vlogging. This type of labour, formally known as digital child labour, still constitutes a fairly recent phenomenon, as it is ingrained in the digital sphere, fairly recent itself. For this reason, no precise definition has been established amongst the academic community yet. However, one can attempt to conceptualize this phenomenon by considering both the concept of ‘child labour’, known

as “the use of children to do work that should be done by adults” (*child labour*, n.d.) and ‘digital’, “using or relating to digital signals and computer technology” (*digital*, n.d.). Zhouzheng relates this practice to the advancement of technology and the consequent expansion of labour structures, which lead to the rise of young internet personalities (2021).

For the time being, and as long as there is not an international consensus on how to protect the children involved in YouTube labour, the only standardized norm that is available to content creators is YouTube’s own policy. The platform’s guidelines don’t allow “content that endangers the emotional and physical well-being of minors” to be posted and warns users to not post content with minors that is “filmed in private spaces at home such as bedrooms or bathrooms” or that “reveals personal details about a minor” (YouTube, n.d.-a, content featuring minors section), under the threat of removal of the content or account blocking. However, it would only take watching a few family vlogs to understand that these policies are not being enforced, as most of the content is recorded throughout the family home and an astonishing amount of personal data is made public. Furthermore, while reading YouTube’s regulations, it becomes clear that these rules only apply to the type of content posted – content that either features minors or is intended to be consumed by them. While arguing that it protects children from “sexualization” or from “harmful or dangerous acts” (YouTube, n.d.-a, what this policy means section), the platform fails to address other fundamental rights, like the “protection from harmful work” and the “protection from exploitation” (UNICEF, n.d., the children's version section), for example. Hence, one can say that YouTube is not fully ensuring the protection of all children’s rights. Accordingly, in Geider’s opinion:

YouTube’s terms of service have not evolved enough to sufficiently address the issue of child safety. YouTube does not address child labour in its terms and conditions. Instead, YouTube advises that it is the parent’s responsibility to understand local child labour laws and to comply with them. (2021, p. 15)

Solely placing the responsibility of these decisions on parents can prove dangerous for children, as multiple cases have surfaced regarding child abuse within the family vlogging community. One of the most remarkable cases is that of the YouTube channel “Fantastic Adventures”, where mother Machel Hackney was arrested and awaiting trial on “24

counts of child abuse, five counts of kidnapping and one count of aggravated assault” (McDonald, 2019). Allegedly, Hackney would starve, restrain and hit her seven children in order to force them to be a part of the videos she would later post on their YouTube channel – that counted 800.000 subscribers (McDonald, 2019). While this might be an extreme example of dangerous parental behaviour using YouTube, until family vlogging is regulated, we will never be able to understand the full scale of the problem, leaving these children vulnerable.

## **2. Literature Review**

A lot has been written about the effects social media has on its users, particularly when those users are children. Studies focus on a varied range of aspect, such as the neurological effects screens have on youngster’s brains, the psychological effects on their behaviours, the changes in their social interactions or the risks they are exposed to by connecting with strangers online. However, what all these approaches have in common is that they continuously perceive the threat as originating from an agent that is external to the child’s inner circle, when in reality the danger might be closer to home, or within home itself. The current thesis aims to possibly explore these same situations where the children’s welfare is being threatened by those closest to them.

According to a study conducted by the software developer AVG, “92% of U.S. 2-year-olds have an online record” (Magid, 2010). These results clearly show how adults are shaping children’s online presence from early on. This type of digital presence is the main topic of Weaver and Gahegan’s 2007 study “Constructing, Visualizing, and Analyzing a Digital Footprint”, as they develop the concept of ‘digital footprints’ - a concept that will be further discussed in the following chapter, ‘Theoretical Framework’. Likewise, Madden et al. (2007) approach the different types of digital impressions, while de Zeeuw (2018) analyses how parents, particularly when using YouTube, are contributing to their children’s online presence. The way that parents build the child’s digital self cannot be fully understood without resorting to the concept of ‘sharenting’, described by McTigue as “parents oversharing about their children online” (McTigue, 2021, p. 2). The concept can also refer to the online sharing of content featuring children and their information in

a broader sense. ‘Sharenting’ has attracted a lot of attention from both media and law academics, such as Sonia Livingstone and Alicia Blum-Ross in their 2017 article “‘Sharenting’, parent blogging, and the boundaries of the digital self”, where they debate the limitations of the parents’ digital self and how it can extend to encompass the child. Stacey Steinberg with her piece “Sharenting: Children’s Privacy in the Age of Social Media”, gives a legally based approach on the phenomenon and proposes a “child-centered, public-health-based model of reform” (Steinberg, 2017, p. 840) to defend the child’s best interests. Alongside the more theoretical approaches to sharenting, there is one study that brought to light worrying data on the topic, namely the “National Poll on Children’s Health” conducted by the C.S. Mott Children’s Hospital in 2015, in partnership with the University of Michigan. According to this investigation 27% of the parents within the study’s sample had shared improper photos of a child, 51% shared details that could lead to the child’s whereabouts and 56% had shared information considered embarrassing regarding their children (C.S. Mott Children’s Hospital, 2015, social media experiences of parents section). This data appears in a time where children’s online privacy is more debated than ever before. Important contributions to understand how adults are spreading children’s information on social media and how to keep them safe online have been given by Palfrey et al. (2010) and by Minkus et al. (2015), respectively. On a similar note, Shmueli and Blecher-Prigat (2011) not only discuss children’s privacy online, but they also analyse it in the light of the current legislation. Additionally, specialists like Dr. Emma Nottingham – Co-Director of the University of Winchester’s Centre for Information Rights and Senior Lecturer in Law – alert lawmakers for the fact that “children who appear on YouTube will slip through the net yet again as more attention is being given to the issues relating to children using social on social media rather than appearing on it” (2019, p. 2), as current policies need to adapt to this new digital reality.

As one elaborates on social media platforms it is imperative to mention the extensive and important work of Abidin and Leaver as they greatly contribute to the mapping of platforms like Instagram, Facebook, Twitter, TikTok and YouTube (Abidin, 2017, 2019, 2020; Abidin et al., 2020; Highfield & Leaver, 2015, 2016; Leaver, 2015). Regarding YouTube in particular, the subject of analysis of the current paper, one piece stands out from the remaining literature - Burgess and Green’s 2009 book titled “YouTube: Online Video and Participatory Culture”, where they dissect the platform’s origins, political

implications and its impacts within the social context. The platform has also motivated multiple data analysis that break down different YouTube characteristics. One of these studies followed the most popular YouTube channels for a week and generated abundant and relevant data on some topics, one of them being children. The study points out that “videos for children – as well as those featuring children – received a large number of views during the study period relative to other topical categories” (Van Kessel et al., 2019, p. 6). These results demonstrate just how influential children and children’s content are on YouTube, as they contribute to the channel’s popularity and subsequently augment revenue. Children’s relevance in the YouTube ecosystem puts them at increased risk for exploitation, namely by their parents, a phenomenon that worked as a catalyst for the current thesis. Similarly, other studies develop on the possible exploitation of children on YouTube and its possible effects, such as Stauff’s dissertation “Parenting in the Public Eye: The Dangers of Sharenting” and Talukdar’s article “The Adverse Effects of Family Vlogging on Children”, both from 2020. However, both Stauff and Talukdar refrain from framing this possible exploitation within a rights-based approach, contrarily to what this study aims to do.

Using a rights-based approach to frame the possible digital labour children are being subjected to by their parents on YouTube, is key to not only comprehend this practice but also to contribute to its cease. On a similar note, some authors do lay out legal foundations on this topic. Geider (2021), details the legislative background for children within the entertainment industry. Furthermore, both Masterson (2018) and Riggio (2021) analyse the differences and similarities between children within the entertainment industry and those featured on social media platforms, and present suggestions on how to regulate this activity. Still on the same note, Steinberg’s work titled “Sharenting: Children's Privacy in the Age of Social Media” provides a crucial legally based perspective on the topic, by arguing that:

(...) parents act as both gatekeepers of their children’s personal information and as narrators of their children’s personal stories. This dual role of parents in their children’s online identity gives children little protection as their online identity evolves. A conflict of interests exists as children might one day resent the disclosures made years earlier by their parents. (2017, p. 839)

This conflict of interests mentioned by Steinberg and the different legislative systems within each country, hinder the reach of a consensus on the topic and therefore delay the possibility to implement clear and concise regulation to protect the minors involved, leaving them vulnerable to the dangers of the digital world.

Thus, the current study, not only addresses the way children are being used for a highly profitable industry like YouTube, but also aims to frame this phenomenon in the light of children's rights, as it is an unprecedented approach to the topic that can lead to meaningful contributions to the discussion.

## **3. Theoretical Framework**

### **3.1. Surveillance**

#### **3.1.1. Surveillance Theory**

The work of Christian Fuchs on media and society has been of great contribute to the field of Media and Communication Studies. The author's positions on political, economic and societal issues concerning digital media gave the field multiple critical theories. One of these theories is of particular importance and helped ground the current thesis, the "Political Economy and Surveillance Theory". Throughout this piece, Fuchs analyses Karl Marx's work and establishes a bridge between the German philosopher's Cycle of Accumulation Theory and the concept of surveillance.

The academic community has different thoughts on Marx's approach to the concept of surveillance. While some argue the concept was entirely overlooked by Marx, others acknowledge that the author approached the concept but consider it was done on different levels of depth (Fuchs, 2012). For Fuchs, not only did Marx address surveillance in his work but he did it in a way that enables surveillance studies to be consistently connected to it. To contextualize his theory, Fuchs starts off by explaining that "for Karl Marx, surveillance is a fundamental aspect of the capitalist economy and the modern nation state" (2012, p. 674). Surveillance can embody multiple formats, have different motivations and be found in all parts of today's society. For Fuchs, surveillance is "the

collection of data on individuals or groups to control and discipline their behaviour” and it works as an “instrument and a means for trying to derive and accumulate benefits for certain groups or individuals at the expense of other groups or individuals” (2012, p. 685). Amongst the different types of societal surveillance detailed by the author, two of them proved to be of particular relevance for the current paper, as they are interconnected with the explored topics: lateral surveillance and consumer surveillance (Fuchs, 2012). Lateral surveillance can be conceptualized as a type of entertainment based on monitorization, like the reality tv format. In reality, family vlogging matches some of the characteristics of reality tv, as real life is recorded, shared and then later consumed as entertainment. The second one, consumer surveillance, concerns the use of internet platforms, like YouTube, and their use of surveillance for profit. With data currently being a valuable asset, social media websites have a major advantage compared to other types of platforms, as they can easily collect detailed information on their users and later sell it for advertising purposes. For this reason, with data being considered an asset, the process of creating it should be considered labour, as “real labour is purposeful activity aimed at the creation of a use value, at the appropriation of natural material in a manner which corresponds to particular needs” (Marx, 1861, p.63, as cited in Fuchs & Sevignani, 2013, p. 239). Accordingly, YouTube users, particularly the ones uploading content, like family vloggers, can be considered employees for YouTube. By consenting to YouTube’s terms and conditions when enrolling into the platform, users are basically signing their own labour contract, “the legally binding relation between a specific employer and a specific employee” (Fuchs, 2012, p. 679). This hypothesis matches Graham and Anwar’s conceptualization of digital labour, “labour that is both income generating and digitally-intensive” (2018, p. 2) and is directly connected to Marx’s perspective of a capitalistic society.

Marx’s views on labour are partly based on the cycle of capital accumulation he formulated. Fuchs explains this cycle by detailing that “capitalists buy labour power and means of production (...) in order to produce new commodities that are sold with the expectation of making money profit that is partly reinvested” (2012, p. 675). For Marx, the only way to increase capital, or generate “surplus value”, is through the “exploitation of labour” (Fuchs, 2012, p. 679), since in his perspective workers have no control over the work they do or the value they create. To achieve this, capitalists adopt a surveillance approach, that can be classified as “a coercive and technological method for controlling and disciplining workers” (Fuchs, 2012, p. 675). However, on social media, this

exploitation is often disguised behind the notion of “playbour”, defined by Fuchs and Sevignani as the “online activity that is fun and work at the same time” (2013, p. 237). With the merge of these two spheres, the author argues that digital work “resembles housework because it has no wages, is mainly conducted during spare time, has no trade union representation and is difficult to perceive as being labour” (Fuchs, 2014, p. 273).

Ultimately, from a digital labour perspective, family vloggers find themselves simultaneously being exploited and exploiting – not only are they employed by YouTube but they also employ their own children. For these children, exploited workers within the ‘family business’, family vlogging constitutes a form of surveillance itself, as it monitors their every move and enforces exploitation patterns.

### **3.1.2. Surveillance Economy**

When analysing family vlogging practices in the light of surveillance, it is crucial to mention an important intervenient, if not the most important one, YouTube. Owned by Google, YouTube plays a key role, alongside Facebook and other platforms, in the maintenance of the huge database the company has, not only on its users, but frankly, on anyone these days.

In increasingly digital times, where ‘playbour’ has become the norm and where “producing data is a form of labour” (Athreya, 2020, p. 84), a new economic reality seems to be emerging, surveillance economy. This new economic structure is founded upon a concept formulated by Shoshana Zuboff, ‘surveillance capitalism’. According to Zuboff, this economic system “claims human experience as free raw material for hidden commercial practices of extraction, prediction, and sales” (2019a, p. 8) and consists in a “mutation of capitalism marked by concentrations of wealth, knowledge, and power unprecedented in human history” (2019a, p. 8).

To better understand this phenomenon, one must look at its origins. In 2001, amidst the early 2000’s recession, “Google invented and perfected surveillance capitalism” (Zuboff, 2019a, p. 16) as a strategic move towards financial recovery. Signifying that “Google would both repurpose its growing cache of behavioural data, now put to work as a behavioural data surplus, and develop methods to aggressively seek new sources of this



surplus” (Zuboff, 2019b, n.p.). These methods are based on active and intrusive surveillance, to not only monitor the user’s activity, but eventually shape it, making surveillance “the business model of the internet” (Schneier, 2017, n.p.). A clear example of this surveillance can be seen through the sale of smart speakers, like Amazon’s ‘Alexa’ or Google’s ‘Google Nest’, that more than speakers are informers, always recording our conversations. “Paradoxically, this coup is celebrated as ‘personalisation’, although it defiles, ignores, overrides, and displaces everything (...) that is personal (Zuboff, 2019b, n.p.). Zuboff goes even further in characterizing this phenomenon, by asserting that:

This power to shape behaviour for others’ profit or power is entirely self-authorising. It has no foundation in democratic or moral legitimacy, as it usurps decision rights and erodes the processes of individual autonomy that are essential to the function of a democratic society. The message here is simple: Once I was mine. Now I am theirs. (2019b, n.p.)

As a platform that hosts a large scale of incredibly personal content, YouTube purposefully enables the use of attention-grabbing mechanisms to increase views, as in the end the platform is the biggest beneficiary from this attention economy, by selling the information it gathers on its users to advertisement companies.

Concerning family vlogging, and as previously mentioned, the platform’s terms and conditions are incomplete, as they do not address child labour. Furthermore, it only takes a brief analysis of this type of content to find infringements of the rules without any visible consequences. By turning a blind eye to scenarios of child exploitation and child endangerment, YouTube allows its users to benefit from these practices. After all, by allowing this, YouTube is just increasing its own profits. Ultimately, this gain is not comparable to the one obtained by users, as it represents the real financial benefit.

### **3.2. Attention Economy**

With social media playing such an important role within today’s society, content creation has become easier and more available than ever. Social media platforms give not only the tools and the space to create content, but also the platform to share it with the world, which generates an overwhelming amount of data. Simultaneously, today’s society lives

an astounding fast paced life, which diminishes the amount of time available to consume all this content. Hence, with this much information accessible at any time, it becomes increasingly hard to filter what we want to focus on. For this reason, author Michael Goldhaber decided to theorize on this phenomenon, and eventually the concept of ‘attention economy’ was developed. Attention economy addresses the fact that “in the new realities of information overload, human concentration is limited, and attention is a form of cumulative wealth” (Abidin, 2020, pp. 81-82). On YouTube, millions of videos are uploaded every minute, which according to Goldhaber’s hypothesis, multiplies the value of the viewer’s attention. This attention comes not only from an interest in what the messenger is conveying, but also from the wish to fulfil a need or desire the viewer might have (Goldhaber, 1997). On YouTube, this attention is subsequently translated into monetary value with the conversion of views, as the platform “seeks to transform the free exchange of cultural ‘gifts’ into an attention economy monetized through advertising revenue” (Burgess & Green, 2009, p. 120). This monetization creates a greedy competition for the audience’s attention and drives YouTubers to develop multiple strategies in order to obtain it. One of these approaches is the use of ‘spectacular bodies’, as described by Nielsen and Peterson in their work “The spectacular bodies of mukbang videos”. In this article, the authors explain how the spectacular is being used to capture the viewer’s attention, as “spectacularity implies the capacity to generate attention” (Nielsen & Petersen, 2021, p. 124). Family vloggers are no exception to this phenomenon, particularly ‘The Bucket List Family’. While exploring the world, the family engages in thrilling activities, such as cage diving with white sharks, and they often encourage their children to participate in them. While exposing their children to potentially hazardous situations, they increase the audience’s interest and engagement with the content, as the “viewers’ perception and feelings [are] determined by the real risk of the scene” (Nielsen & Petersen, 2021, p. 126). The involvement of children can perhaps increase the success of this approach, since concerns for the children’s wellbeing might exist amongst the general public. Simultaneously, another strategy used to capitalize on the viewer’s attention is the use of ‘clickbait’. Clickbait refers to a common practice within YouTube, where creators purposefully write the titles of their videos in a misleading and/or sensationalized way to drive users to click on them. Likewise, the ‘Bucket List Family’ also engages in this practice, as their channel includes videos titles like “5 YR OLD Jumps Out of Helicopter Into Ocean!” and “Little Girl Surfs with Big Shark in Hawaii”. Furthermore, in the case of the Gee family, these two practices are complementary, as

they not only address spectacular situations, but they also instrumentalize the children's participation in them. These strategies are also addressed by García-Rapp in her 2017 article "Popularity markers on YouTube's attention economy: the case of Bubzbeauty", where she emphasises the magnitude and power they can exert over viewers by using the term 'claws' to refer to them (García-Rapp, 2017, p. 232).

### **3.3. Calibrated Amateurism and Public Intimacy**

While being "chiefly premised on being ordinary, everyday, and mundane" (Abidin, 2017, p. 4), family vlogs, like the ones shared by 'The Bucket List Family', have evolved into high quality productions. High resolution cameras, planned content and scripted interactions put these videos in an ambiguous position, between the amateur and the professional. Abidin describes this peculiar situation as calibrated amateurism:

a practice and aesthetic in which actors in an attention economy labour specifically over crafting contrived authenticity that portrays the raw aesthetic of an amateur, whether or not they really are amateurs by status or practice, by relying on the performance ecology of appropriate platforms, affordances, tools, cultural vernacular, and social capital. (2017, p. 1)

However, despite all the production involved in creating these videos, when visiting the family's channel on YouTube, one can still perceive their content as honest and authentic. Abidin addresses this phenomenon by explaining that "when orchestrated conscientiously, calibrated amateurism may give the impression of spontaneity and unfilteredness despite the contrary reality" (2017, p. 7). Fabricated or not, these videos are able to establish an emotional and intimate connection with the audience (Berryman & Kavka, 2018). Nevertheless, the increase of popularity for highly personal videos, like family vlogs, suggests that we are moving towards a new level of exposure, labelled by Marshall as 'public intimacy' – "where it becomes hard to distinguish between "what is public and what is private and, ultimately, what is intimate" (Marshall, 2014, p. 12) and where "fame and celebrity are naturally linked with private revelation for public consumption" (Marshall, 2014, p. 13). On YouTube, this almost voyeuristic fascination that audiences have with the private sphere contributed to the growth of the popularity of both vlogging and family vlogging, turning once anonymous users into overnight

celebrities and demonstrating, therefore, the relevance the platform has in establishing the “inherent social significance of new types of celebrities” (García-Rapp, 2017, p. 230). According to García-Rapp, the key to build a “long-lasting supporting audience and loyal fans” is the “performance of self-presentation and self-expression, coordinated through ongoing content management and strong community ties” (2017, p. 241). For family vloggers, this performance is frequently associated with one’s parenting style, instrumentalizing the children as accessories to the act and often behaving like opinion leaders. To succeed, family vloggers “must carefully curate and promote an online identity as if it were a branded good” (Pers, n.d., who are mommy vloggers section), as we can see through the Gee family’s website, where they openly discuss their performance on multiple social media platforms and the achievements obtained by the family brand. Moreover, as these seemingly average parents become celebrities, one can argue that their role in these videos is nothing more than a calculated expression of self or a fabricated persona – a designation that “identifies what we all engage in as we publicize, perform, and present versions of ourselves” (Marshall, 2014, p. 35).

### **3.4. Privacy of the Child**

In an increasingly digital world, individuals are not only exposed to a digital dimension but also encouraged to be a part of it, becoming themselves content creators and, therefore ‘prosumers’ – a concept characterizing consumers who become involved with content production for their own needs (*prosumer*, n.d.). Correspondingly, while producing and sharing their own content, namely on YouTube, users generate a record of online presence. Weaver and Gahegan define this record as “every shred of digital data - every movement, every transaction, every record - is woven together into a single virtual database. For a given individual, we refer to his or her accumulated trace as a ‘digital footprint’” (2007, p. 329). This multidimensional digital record is “characterized by digital transactions, augmented by surveillance, and influenced by associations and patterns throughs pace and time” (Weaver & Gahegan, 2007, p. 330). Nevertheless, its construction is highly complex and relies on both voluntary and involuntary actions from users. This process is explored by Madden et al. as they distinguish the two main types of digital traces. The first one, active footprints, concerns “personal data made accessible online through deliberate posting or sharing of information by the user” (Madden et al., 2007, p. 4), for example the data collected while creating a YouTube channel or the information gathered from an uploaded vlog. The second one deals with the “personal

data made accessible online with no deliberate intervention from an individual” (Madden et al., 2007, p. 3), and is referred to as passive footprints. Examples of this type of record would be the use of IP address information or the identification of the user’s location through the detection of geolocation from their device. However, with sharenting practices flooding social media, a new type of digital footprint seems to have emerged – “pre-made digital footprints”, a concept coined by de Zeeuw (2018, p. 5). While engaging in family vlogging, parents are actively sharing personal data from the family unit, which includes not only themselves but also their children. For the children, sharing their information with an audience of strangers is not a choice, but an imposed reality. By sharing so much personal information online, parents might not realise that they are putting their children in a vulnerable and dangerous situation. Cases have been reported where images of children obtained from family vlogs were uploaded to online paedophile communities, such as the case of the YouTube channel ‘The Life of a Homemaker’. Additionally, another concern is the risk of digital kidnapping, where adults are caught “role playing with photos of other people’s children stolen from social media accounts” (O’Neil, 2015). YouTube provides yet another potential harmful consequence of sharenting - fan accounts. By finding accessible content online, so called fans, can create new accounts related to the children, produce new content and further contribute to their online exposure. Nevertheless, “no less serious, are the longer-term legal, moral, and psychological consequences to filming, and making celebrities out of your children” (Tait, 2015). These consequences can take years to appear and are still virtually unknown, as the first children who were involved in this type of videos are only now reaching adulthood. To make things worse, it has been proven that “data disclosed online are often persistent, searchable, and hard to delete” (Palfrey et al., 2010, p. 11), which emphasizes the long-lasting nature of these consequences.

Public debate on children’s rights regarding online exposure has been intensifying. For Livingstone, the discussion around sharenting practices should be “matter of respect and consent (...) more than the actual fact of sharing itself” (Livingstone, 2018). This consent is deeply connected to already established rights to privacy. The United Nations states that “privacy is vital to children’s agency, dignity and safety and for the exercise of their rights” (United Nations, 2021, p. 11) and goes further by explaining that sharenting practices, like family vlogging, “may lead to arbitrary or unlawful interference with children’s right to privacy” (United Nations, 2021, p. 11). Shmueli and Blecher-Prigat

argue that “children should have an individual right for privacy against their parents, while recognizing that this right should be qualified according to the child’s age and evolving capacities” (2011, p. 763). Allowing children to have an active role in decision-making, especially when those decisions directly impact their future, is crucial to ensure that the children’s best interest is being protected. To help guide governments on how to legislate and parents on how to adequately include their children, Hart, on behalf of UNICEF, has developed the illustrative “ladder of participation”, that can be seen on figure 3.

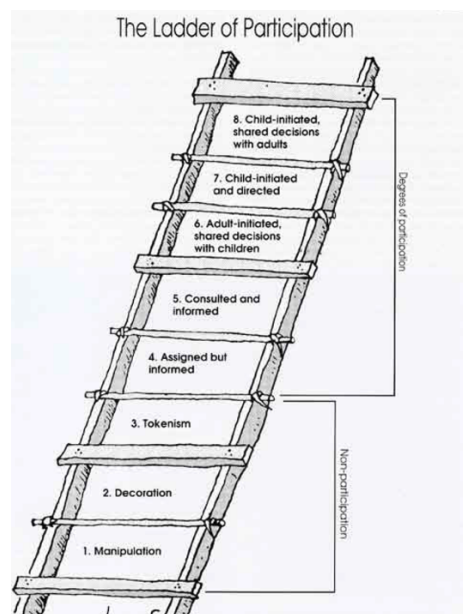


Figure 3: 'The Ladder of Participation'  
Source: Hart (1992, p. 8)

‘Participation’ is defined by Hart as “the process of sharing decisions which affect one’s life and the life of the community in which one lives” and constitutes a “fundamental right of citizenship” (1992, p. 5). For this reason, ensuring children’s agency is an important part of UNICEF’s plea with governments. Accordingly, in 2014, the European Union promulgated a new version of the General Data Protection Regulation (GDPR), which included the “right to be forgotten” - a new law that guarantees children’s agency by stating that “video platforms will be required to remove the child’s videos upon his or her direct request, even without the parents’ consent” (Boring, 2020).

Children’s rights, however, like human rights, are susceptible to public debate and inquiry, as rights are “primarily ethical demands. They are not principally “legal,” “proto-legal” or “ideal-legal” commands” (Sen, 2004, p. 319). As a matter of fact, it can be

theorized that “international human rights is the world's first universal ideology” (Weissbrodt, 1988, p.1, as cited in Turner, 1993, p. 490). Moreover, Turner describes human rights as “extra-political or supra-societal rights which have their legitimacy beyond the state, are crucial in protecting individuals against state violence, or at least in providing the normative grounds on which individuals could be protected against state violence” (1993, p. 502). Institutions like governments and legislation, are intended to protect individuals, nonetheless, by enjoying a status of power they are often the first ones to compromise this mission (Turner, 1993, pp. 501-502). The same scenario applies for families, as they are the main responsible party for the safety of a child. However, when engaging in sharenting practices, like the upload of family vlogs, they are endangering the child. Furthermore, it can be argued that “by creating and sharing content, children may be economic actors in the digital environment, which may result in their exploitation” (United Nations, 2021, p. 19). This scenario is gradually becoming a reality, as minors are being portrayed as central figures in the videos and working on what is the main source of income for many family units. “For most working children and youth, however, the work is better called ‘labour’: it is not meaningful and they did not choose it, and it is often exploitative or hazardous” (Hart, 1992, p. 21). Ultimately, “choice is an important distinction in determining whether a child is participating or being exploited” (Hart, 1992, p. 21).

## 4. Methodology

“Methodology is not value in itself”, but rather a tool to “evaluate the performance of individual techniques; and to estimate the likelihood of particular research designs to contribute to knowledge” (Krippendorff, 2004, p. 21). Therefore, choosing what methods to use plays a crucial role in determining the outcome of the research itself. To guarantee an appropriate choice of method, one must evaluate the compatibility with the research questions. For the current thesis, the selected research questions – (RQ1) ‘How and to what extent are YouTube family vloggers using their children as labour for the ‘family business’?’ and (RQ2) ‘How can these new practices be analysed in the light of children’s rights?’ – embody both qualitative and quantitative dimensions, and, therefore, pair with the choice of mixed methodology. Simultaneously, it is also crucial to consider the characteristics of the domain studied, in this case, the digital universe.

## 4.1. Mixed Methods Approach

The digital sphere is often perceived as an exclusively numerical domain, as mathematical structures of coding and software are the main constituents of its structure. However, all these systems are not only developed by humans but also continuously shaped by them – as is the case of social media. Accordingly, using social media for data collection, accounts for both humanistic (qualitative) and mechanical (quantitative) domains (Lynch & Gerber, 2021). Hence, the method chosen for the current research is a mixed methods approach of content analysis, as “it is reasonable to suggest that any research involving digital data and analysis is inherently mixed” (Lynch & Gerber, 2021, p. 219). For Creswell and Clark, mixed methods is an approach where the researcher:

collects and analyzes both qualitative and quantitative data rigorously in response to research questions and hypotheses, integrates (or mixes or combines) the two forms of data and their results, organizes these procedures into specific research designs that provide the logic and procedures for conducting the study, and frames these procedures within theory and philosophy. (2018, p. 41)

By combining the two approaches, the researcher not only heightens their strengths but also diminishes their limitations (Creswell & Creswell, 2018, p. 297), which allows for the “broad purpose of breadth and depth of understanding and corroboration” (Johnson et al., 2007, p. 123). Nevertheless, it is because of both qualitative and quantitative approaches that the choice of a content analysis becomes relevant, as it aims to “preserve the advantages of quantitative content analysis as developed within communication science and to transfer and further develop them to qualitative-interpretative steps of analysis” (Mayring, 2000, p. 1). Ultimately, the use of a content analysis for this project, aims to directly answer the two proposed research questions, by providing real quantifiable data to understand the extent of the children’s involvement in the ‘family business’, conducting a comprehensive analysis of the video content uploaded by the family, and by using children’s rights as a compass to guide the analysis. The term ‘content analysis’ dates back to the 1960’s, when it first became an official part of the Webster’s Dictionary of English Language as “analysis of the manifest and latent content of a body of communicated material (...) through classification, tabulation, and evaluation



of its key symbols and themes in order to ascertain its meaning and probable effect” (Webster's Dictionary of the English Language, 1961, as cited in Krippendorff, 2004, p. 17).

Even if different in many ways, the two approaches share some common features like “the sampling and data collection strategy (...), the coding process (...) and validation of study results” (Hamad et al., 2016, p. 2). However, it is still important to address them individually. A qualitative content analysis “is a method for systematically describing the meaning of qualitative material” (Schreier, 2012, p. 1). This method adopts a more subjective nature of analysis and according to Schreier can be characterized as “interpretive, naturalistic, situational, reflexive, (...), case-oriented and emphatic on validity” (2012, p. 21). Moreover, the interpretative character of this method means that meaning is extracted not only from the analysis of the content but also from the context in which this content was produced (Bergman, 2010). On the other hand, a content analysis with a quantitative approach is “an empirical method for the systematic analysis of well-defined, audio, textual, visual and/or audio-visual media content” (Bock et al., 2011, p. 265). This approach, commonly concerns the analysis of a “large quantity of media messages” in order to “produce generalizable predictions” (Bock et al., 2011, pp. 265-266), and can be characterized by an objective, numerical and practical style of data analysis. Nevertheless, Schram argues that a content analysis is “primarily a quantitative technique used to count words or phrases, when in fact it fits very well into the structure of mixed methods” (2014, p. 2621). Accordingly, and because of the domain being studied, it is important to acknowledge that “when it comes to social media data, the qualitative and the quantitative are inseparable” (Lynch & Gerber, 2021, p. 219).

## **4.2. Research Paradigms**

It is also essential to identify which viewpoints guide the researcher throughout the research, formally referred to as ‘research paradigms’. A paradigm is “a model or frame of reference through which to observe and understand” (Babbie, 2013, p. 57). In other words, it is a “basic belief system and theoretical framework with assumptions about ontology, epistemology, methodology and methods” (Rehman & Alharthi, 2016, p. 51), that works as a compass for researchers to conduct their work. Ontology and epistemology can be considered as the structure that underlies the whole research, as

ontology can be understood as “the nature of our beliefs about reality” (Richards, 2003, p. 33), and epistemology as “the nature of knowledge and the process by which knowledge is acquired and validated” (Gall et al., 2007, p. 13). Additionally, methodology and methods are interdependent elements, as they both concern processes of collection, management and analysis of data.

The current research follows an interpretivist perspective, as its aim is “not to discover universal, context and value free knowledge and truth but to try to understand the interpretations of individuals about the social phenomena they interact with” (Rehman & Alharthi, 2016, p. 55). Analysing the videos posted by ‘The Bucket List Family’ will not provide absolute truths about the possibility of digital child labour. Instead, it will allow for a societal-based interpretation of the context in which they are produced. Accordingly, interpretivist ontology argues that “it is not possible to know reality as it is because it is always mediated by our senses” (Rehman & Alharthi, 2016, p. 55). Rehman and Alharthi also argue that “interpretive epistemology is subjective”, as “external reality cannot be directly accessible to observers without being contaminated by their worldviews, concepts, backgrounds (...)” (2016, p. 55). For this reason, methodological approaches guided by interpretivism are designed to “understand social phenomena in their context” (Rehman & Alharthi, 2016, p. 56). Ultimately, a mixed methods approach can perfectly fit these perspectives, as researchers following an interpretivist paradigm usually use methods that produce both qualitative and quantitative results - even if these last ones are not the main goal or focus of the research (Rehman & Alharthi, 2016, p. 56).

Due to the fact that YouTube has plenty of channels that fit within the family vlogging category, and because “the vastness of available content presents some challenges at the acquiring stage, particularly with regard to sampling” (Neuendorf, 2017, p. 213), this thesis was conducted using a case study approach. A qualitative research method that is used to “explore and investigate contemporary real-life phenomenon through detailed contextual analysis of a limited number of events or conditions, and their relationships” (Zainal, 2007, pp. 1-2). Hence, a case study is “the most flexible of all research designs, allowing the researcher to retain the holistic characteristics of real-life events while investigating empirical events” (Schell, 1992, p. 2). Therefore, the use of this approach allows for a deeper and contextualized understanding of the practice of family vlogging.

### 4.3. Qualitative Approach

As part of the qualitative approach to this research, a sample of five videos was created from the 'Bucket List Family's YouTube channel. The number of videos being analysed was decided based on the intention to conduct an extensive analysis of each one of them, which would only be possible through the selection of a smaller sample. Furthermore, the fact that the videos uploaded by the Gee family all follow a similar structure, also justifies the selection of a smaller sample. The choice of the videos was made based on the number of views obtained. The filter 'Most Popular Videos' was applied to the playlist, providing access to a real-time overview of the most watched videos uploaded by the family. This choice is based on the fact that views and profit are deeply connected. Therefore, by analysing the videos with the most views one can comprehend the true influence these children have as active figures in the family's 'business'.

To help categorize the findings obtained by this analysis, a thematic codebook was created. However, in order to better adjust the categories of analysis to the content of the videos, the structure of the codebook was only "established following some preliminary examination of the data" (Stemler, 2000, p. 2). This preliminary examination consisted of viewing the channel's most recent video "Wake Surf Lessons for Kids – Baby and 5 year old swim routine in Deep Lake", that was posted on the 15<sup>th</sup> of May 2022. The 22 minutes long video revolves entirely around the exposure of the kids to wake surfing while adults, including their parents, cheer them on. With the kids being the central figure in the whole video, there is a great amount of attention placed on their performance in the activity. Accordingly, throughout the video it is common to see the kids' emotions on display, as is the case with the youngest son, Calihan. Towards the end of the video, the 4-year-old, is forced to wake surf with his dad, despite the fact that he is visibly terrified, as he cries and repeatedly says he does not want to do it. This exposure of the children's emotions clearly portrays them in vulnerable situations in front of an audience of total strangers. Moreover, throughout the video the parents can be seen encouraging the kids to participate in the activity and talking about their parenting techniques - the dad, Garret, states "you don't want to traumatize them, but you want to push them outside of their comfort zone (...)" (The Bucket List Family, 2022, 17:08). Through this preliminary analysis of the content, it was then possible to develop an appropriate coding frame. This frame consists of two variables of analysis:

**Variable 01.** Situations the children are being exposed to

**Attributes** - This variable concerns the types of activities the children are participating in, whether voluntarily or forced. The risks associated with the situations they are exposed to and the appropriateness of the situation regarding the children's age and abilities are also considered.

**Variable 02.** Parents' interactions with the children

**Attributes** - This variable concerns the dynamics between the parents and the children throughout the video, particularly when the family engages in situations that leave the children more exposed.

## 4.4. Quantitative Approach

When it comes to the quantitative analysis, the data collection was based on a sample of 100 videos. The sampling was, once again, based on the criteria of the 'most popular videos', choosing the 100 most watched ones, and having their financial relevance as the main reason for this decision.

This quantitative content analysis focuses on the titles of the videos, as they have the role of getting viewers interested in choosing to watch a specific video. Accordingly, they can be perceived as welcoming and inviting elements, as they are often the first contact viewers have with the channel.

A codebook was created in order to facilitate the sorting and collection of data. This codebook follows a structure that acts like a filter while analysing the collected material (Schreier, 2012, p. 63). This structure, or coding frame is based on one single category - 'reference to minors in the video title'. The first step was to determine the presence of vocabulary portraying minors in the titles of the videos. In order to identify this category within the analysis, the following variables were defined:

**Variable 01.** Child/Children

**Attributes** - "a young person especially between infancy and puberty" (*child*, n.d.).

**Variable 02. Kid/Kids/Little Kids**

**Attributes** - “a young person” (*kid*, n.d.).

**Variable 03. Baby**

**Attributes** - “an extremely young child” (*baby*, n.d.).

**Variable 04. Boy/Little Boy**

**Attributes** - “a male child from birth to adulthood” (*boy*, n.d.).

**Variable 05. Girl/ Little Girl**

**Attributes** - “a female child from birth to adulthood” (*girl*, n.d.).

**Variable 06. Age of the Child**

**Attributes** – Mentioning the age of the child, particularly when that age is still not meeting the legal criteria for constituting an adult, which in the case of the United States (where the family comes from) is at 18 years old.

**Variable 07. Dorothy, Manilla and Calihan**

**Attributes** - The names of the three Gee children, all of them minors.

All these variables, and their inherent meaning, refer to possible ways of identifying a minor. Secondly, after determining the presence of this vocabulary in the video titles, the following step was to characterize this occurrence by counting the use of the different variables.

## **5. Ethics**

Research should be conducted with the highest ethical standards in mind. Nonetheless, researchers, like any other individuals, do not exist in isolation from the rest of society and are subjected to socialization processes that shape them. As a result, no researcher can ever be completely objective when conducting an analysis, especially when examining social meanings and symbols. The choice of the topic itself is already influenced by what piques the researcher's interest and why. Nevertheless, it is critical for

researchers to be aware of their own set of values and beliefs in order to hold themselves ethically accountable during the research.

Data gathered from social media can be characterized as “typically rich, numerous and naturally occurring” (Townsend & Wallace, 2015, p. 4) and can pose new challenges for investigators, as social media constitutes a complex social structure. Accordingly, researchers are forced to “rethink established ethical principles of informed consent, privacy and anonymity” (Sugiura et al., 2017, p. 185). While some argue that it can be “problematic for researchers to justify their actions as ethical simply because the data are accessible (...) research ethics cannot be ignored simply because the data are seemingly public” (boyd & Crawford, 2012, p. 672). Townsend and Wallace dispute this by arguing that “data accessed from open and public online locations (...) present less ethical issues than data which are found in closed or private online spaces” (2015, p. 10). This can be justified by the fact that internet celebrities, like the ‘Bucket List Family’, willingly share a great amount of personal information in order to reach the biggest possible amount of viewers, increasing the difficulties in separating the private and public spheres. Moreover, the fact that social media users agree to the platform’s terms and conditions when creating an account, is often used to justify the ‘free’ use of the data. YouTube itself includes a section in its terms and conditions named ‘Licence to Other Users’, that grants other users of the platform with “worldwide, non-exclusive, royalty-free licence” to access the content and to use it, “including to reproduce, distribute, modify, display, and perform it” (YouTube, 2022). By signing this form, it can be argued that users are, therefore, giving consent to anyone who wants to use their publicly available content. Accordingly, this would mean that the need to ask for consent before the use of public data would not exist, as “there are circumstances where informed consent may not be appropriate” (Gilbert, 2008, p. 317). The current thesis follows this perspective, as the researcher is “confident that no foreseeable harm could accrue to people from use of publicly available data” (Gilbert, 2008, p. 317). Furthermore, even though the content analysed is protected by copyright laws, as long as the appropriate bibliographical references are included, the extraction of video frames for analysis purposes can be seen as ‘fair use’. This special statute is mentioned in YouTube’s regulations and predicted by U.S. law, and it comprehends the use of copyrighted material for “(...) criticism, comment, news reporting, teaching (including multiple copies for classroom use), scholarship, or research

(...)” (U.S. Congress, 1958, section 107) without it constituting a breach of copyright laws.

Children constitute a particularly vulnerable group and therefore need adequate protection. For this reason, and as they are a central part of this research, precautions were taken to protect them, namely by blurring their faces and preventing the further exposure of their identities, as “protecting the identity of unwitting participants becomes even more crucial when the data accessed refers to a sensitive subject matter” (Townsend & Wallace, 2015, p. 7). Moreover, the discussion of delicate topics like child labour and possible violations of children’s rights and the fact that the children cannot advocate for themselves, places an increased chance that the child’s best interests will not be ensured. To prevent this from happening, the current thesis combines the use of so called ‘big data’ – data gathered from social media – with a qualitative approach to its analysis, in order to provide context and allow for a better understanding of the situation, as advised by Berman et al. (2018, p. 22).

## **6. Presentation and Analysis of Results**

The current chapter will present an overview of the obtained results and a complete analysis of them.

### **6.1. Quantitative Approach**

By analysing the titles of the top hundred most popular videos in the channel (see appendix 1), it becomes clear just how important the children are to attracting viewers to the channel. One could be surprised by finding out that variables representing vocabulary that refers to minors are only found in 48% of the video titles. However, it is important to scrutinize the remaining 52% in order to get a deep understanding of the representation of these children. For the videos whose title did not contain vocabulary related to minors, it is possible to identify four main topics that were, instead, the focus of these titles – mention to the whole family, the country being visited or travel related information, the activity practiced in the video and mentions to both the mom and the dad. Nonetheless,

even if not directly present in the title, the children often appear in the thumbnail of the video – the icon containing a small image that represents the content of the video. Furthermore, the previously mentioned topics often indirectly include the children, as is the case with titles containing the word ‘family’. From the titles that do contain one or more variables in their text, some conclusions can also be extracted (see appendix 2). The first conclusion concerns the fact that the variable 02, ‘kid/kids/little kids’ was used the most and contrarily variable 01, ‘child/children’ was never used. This might indicate that the use of less formal language is the preferred approach, which can indicate a desire to be closer to the viewer. Moreover, it is possible to identify three other variables as frequently found in the video titles. These variables are respectively, numbers 03, 06 and 07 - ‘baby’, ‘age of the child’ and ‘Dorothy, Manilla and Calihan’. The use of these variables emphasizes the type of highly personal content the family produces, as all these variables represent either details about the minors or the indication of vulnerability, like the case of variables 03 ‘baby’ and variable 06 ‘age of the child’. In the case of the most watched video, “5 YR OLD Scuba Dives with GREAT WHITE SHARKS in Mexico!!”, the age of the child is used to emphasize the spectacularity of the situation. Concerning variables 04 ‘boy/little boy’ and 05 ‘girl/little girl’, even if present in some titles their use is not significant, which could perhaps be explained by the fact that they can be perceived as impersonal when used by parents to refer to their children, similar to the terms ‘child’ and ‘children’.

## **6.2. Qualitative Approach**

The second part of the analysis focused on the five most popular videos uploaded on the channel and provided the researcher with a comprehensive overview of the content produced by the family and children’s role in the videos.

### **6.2.1. First Video**

The first video, “5 YR OLD Scuba Dives with GREAT WHITE SHARKS in Mexico!!”(The Bucket List Family, 2019), referred to as ‘video 1’ from now on, is the channels most watched video, with a current total of 14 million views. The video alternates between footage captured on the family’s trip and post recorded interview-like footage of the two older children narrating and discussing the events. In this video, the family flies to Mexico and both the parents and the two older children, Dorothy and



Manilla, cage dive with great white sharks. Suspenseful and heroic music is combined with the footage, and metaphors are established between the lyrics and what is happening in the video. In one scene, the kids are recorded looking onto the sea wearing red robes while the lyrics mention the children's tale 'little red riding hood' and compare the sharks with a 'big bad wolf'. The video displays high quality footage, including aerial and underwater shots and is professionally edited, showing the investment of money for video equipment and of time for the preparation of the video. The video also features footage from the safety briefing that the boat's crew gives to all passengers before the cage diving. In this scene, besides the two children only adults can be seen. All participants of the activity must sign consent form and Dorothy can be heard jokingly stating she is "signing her life away" (The Bucket List Family, 2019, 2:17). Throughout the video, the question 'are you scared?' appears multiple times and although most adults can be heard saying they are scared and even recording mock goodbye messages to their families, the kids appear to be fearless. However, Dorothy later admits in the later recorded footage that she was scared but then she was brave. It becomes apparent that cage diving is not intended for children so young as the siblings need to wear weight belts around their waist to keep them submerged (see figure 4) and as Manilla can be seen struggling to fit the oxygen bottle's mouthpiece in his small mouth.



Figure 4: Gee children while scuba diving with great white sharks  
Source: The Bucket List Family (2019)

During the interviews the kids mention that their father had made them dive a second time only in their swimsuits and justifying this request by stating he is "weird, "crazy" and "out of his mind" (The Bucket List Family, 2019, 19:37). Throughout the family's cage

diving experience, the youngest member of the family, Calihan is rarely featured in the video, and at same point his siblings justify this absence by claiming he is “not old enough for sharks” (The Bucket List Family, 2019, 0:33). In terms of the video’s relevance business-wise, four factors can be identified as playing a crucial role in generating profits. The first one concerns that fact that in the 24 minutes the video lasts, five commercials appear, which reveals high monetization patterns. Secondly, the description of the video includes a link for the website of the company hired for the boat expedition which hints a paid partnership between the family and the brand. The third factor, concerns the sale of environmental-friendly merchandise. To promote this merchandise, the kids can be seen playing with the products (as seen in figure 5).



Figure 5: Gee children holding their family’s merchandise  
Source: The Bucket List Family (2019)

Furthermore, in an attempt to not only incentivize the purchase of the products but also increase the engagement with their audience, the parents challenge the viewers to send in photos of themselves with the merchandise. Lastly, clickbait practices can be identified in the video’s thumbnail (see figure 6 below).

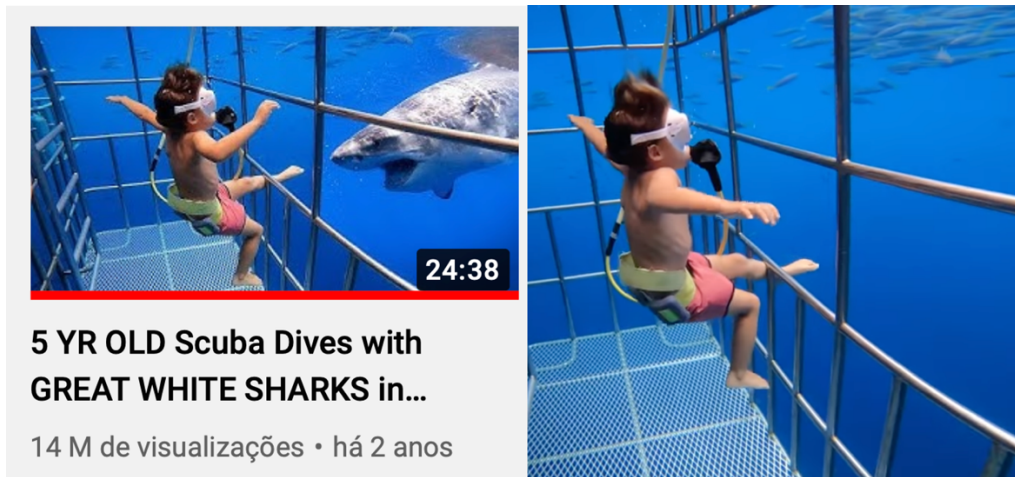


Figure 6: Manipulation of the thumbnail image  
Source: The Bucket List Family (n.d.-b)

It becomes evident by observing figure 6, that the image used for the thumbnail of the video was manipulated to simulate a danger-filled situation, with a shark being placed close to Manilla's foot. This manipulation aims to capture the attention of YouTube users and increase the number of views the video has.

### 6.2.2. Second Video

The second video, "5 YR OLD FREE DIVES THE BLUE HOLE!! /// WEEK 105 : Great Blue Hole, Belize" (The Bucket List Family, 2018a), has 9,2 million views so far and will be referred as 'video 2' from now on. The video begins with a younger Manilla preparing to jump into the water while the father cheers him on by saying "be brave buddy, I'll catch you" (The Bucket List Family, 2018a, 0:03). After jumping, the child goes to mother and she praises him by saying "you are so brave" (The Bucket List Family, 2018a, 2:22). The video goes on by showing mundane footage of the family's life while living on a boat, and at some point, Manilla and Dorothy are recorded as they are in a bed and the boy can be seen naked as he sits there (see figure 7 below).



Figure 7: Manilla being recorded while naked  
Source: The Bucket List Family (2018a)

As the family arrives to the blue hole where they plan to swim, the parents can be heard describing how that week the kids were “not the only people overcoming their fears”, as Jessica, the mother, assumes she was terrified at first. Minutes later, both kids can be seen swimming in the hole. Calihan, a small baby at the time, can also be seen multiple times throughout the video. The video, 17 minutes long, features 6 commercial breaks and includes a link in its description that directs viewers to the website of Cressi, a brand that according to the family, has the “best dive gear for kids”. The inclusion of the link points to a paid partnership with the brand.

### 6.2.3. Third Video

The third video, “Kids Swimming with Sharks!! /// WEEK 107 : Bahamas” (The Bucket List Family, 2018c), will be referred to from now on as ‘video 3’. With 7,8 million views achieved so far, the video begins with Garret asking the audience if sharks are mean or nice and by teasing the audience with the fact the answer will be showed throughout the video. Accompanied by Dorothy, Garret makes an obvious promotion to the resort where the family is staying, and the logo of the hotel chain is even featured in the video, indicating a partnership between the family and the hotel. The first part of the video shows Manilla and Dorothy diving inside a cave with their dad while suspenseful music plays in the background. As Garret and Dorothy discuss the events from that week, Garret praises Dorothy as he recalls that adults that were too scared to dive inside the cave decided to do it after they saw a “little girl swimming like a mermaid who was brave enough to do it” (The Bucket List Family, 2018c, 10:52). Dorothy appears so comfortable with talking to the camera and aware of what usually is said that she even reminds Garret

that he was forgetting to tell the viewers about a part of the trip. The second part of the video shows the family swimming with sharks, with exception to Calihan. Garret tells Dorothy in the post recorded footage that he was worried she would be too scared to do it and tells her he is proud of her for succeeding. As they are in the water with the sharks, Calihan can be seen holding onto his dad while his sister freely swims with the animals and gets close to them (see figure 8).



Figure 8: Dorothy swimming with sharks  
Source: The Bucket List Family (2018c)

The video's description includes direct links to both the resort where the family stayed and the airline they travelled with, as a sign of, yet another, paid partnership. Throughout the video's 19 minutes, 2 commercials pop up to the viewer.

#### **6.2.4. Fourth Video**

'Video 4', with the title "Teaching Our 2 YR OLD BABY to Swim Underwater" (The Bucket List Family, 2020b), already has 5,1 million views and tells the story of Calihan's journey of learning how to swim. The video comprises footage of different trips and has Calihan's evolution as the central narrative. At some point, the dad can be seen holding Calihan up. Just a small baby at the time, Calihan can be seen completely naked and for brief moments the baby's genitalia is slightly visible (see figure 9). By allowing this type of content, despite it clearly going against YouTube's terms and conditions, the platform is allowing financial growth at the expense of these minors, as in the end, the platform is profiting from this itself.





Figure 9: Calihan being held by his dad while visibly naked  
Source: The Bucket List Family (2020b)

The video also features the rest of the family praising the toddler in multiple occasions. Garret can be seen challenging the two older kids to lay on the snow while only wearing their swimsuits. Before doing it, the kids can be seen saying they are as brave as a dolphin and as brave as a cheetah, in order to show that they are fearless and will do it. Dorothy can be seen laying in the snow for a few seconds before quickly standing due to the cold as her dad encourages her to do it again. After doing it two times the girl eventually screams “no” to indicate she does not want to do it anymore, and they proceed back into the warm pool. Calihan can be seen trying on new activities, like water slides as the parents praise him and ask him if he wants to repeat it, to which the toddler says ‘no’. On one occasion, the parents try to put a snorkel mask in the boy’s face as he cries and resists it. Eventually they succeed and after a few seconds in the water Calihan can be seen back on the boat coughing, presumably from ingesting a small portion of water. The video displays 2 commercials during its 20 minutes and a link can be found in its description, connecting the viewer with the boat company present in one part of the video.

### **6.2.5. Fifth Video**

The last video, “BABY SWIM LESSONS - The Ultimate Routine to Help Our 2 YR OLD Swim and Deep Dive Underwater” (The Bucket List Family, 2020a), referred to as ‘video 5’ from now on, presents a total of 4,7 million views so far. The video’s structure differs from the usual one used in the other videos. The shorter video, only 12 minutes long, only features Garret and Calihan and does not follow a video diary approach, as it adopts a tutorial style. The video shows Garret teaching Calihan how to swim and is accompanied by inspirational music and Garret’s voice narrating the scene, as he compares swimming

lessons with parenting and gives advice to other parents by using concepts like ‘trust’ and ‘safety’. The footage is recorded by a set of cameras placed in different angles, including underwater, and contrarily to what usually is seen on other videos, Garret does not hold the camera himself, which indicates that the video was extensively planned. Towards the end of the video, Calihan’s progress can be seen as the toddler is recorded touching the bottom of the pool’s deepest end (see figure 10).



Figure 10: Calihan touching the deepest end of the pool  
Source: The Bucket List Family (2020a)

In the video’s description links to the family’s website, their monthly subscription club and other videos from the family’s channel can be found. Additionally, mentions are made to that month’s special brand partnerships and discounts. The link to a video from Dorothy’s own YouTube channel is linked and so is another child’s YouTube channel, as the two girls appear to have done a collaboration on their channels. A common practice amongst Youtubers to help their channels ‘grow’, by appearing in each other’s videos and introducing themselves to the other channel’s audience.

#### **6.2.6. Analysing the Five Videos**

To analyse these videos as a whole, it is important to use the pre-established variables, variable 01 ‘Situations the children are being exposed to’ and variable 02 ‘Parents’ interactions with the children’, to guide the process. Regarding the first variable, it becomes obvious that the children are being exposed to thrilling and extraordinary scenarios like swimming with sharks, a situation present in videos 1 and 3. Besides these uncommon activities that the children engage in, the parents also encourage them to step

out of their comfort zones and overcome their fears, as it happens when Calihan learns how to swim. Therefore, we can categorize the situations the kids are exposed to, in both a physical way, through engaging in practical activities, and a psychological way, as they are constantly being pushed to learn and overcome fears. Concerning, variable 2, the dynamics between the parents and the children are mainly based on encouragement to achieve something and consequent praise for succeeding. The word ‘brave’ is frequently used, both to motivate the children and to describe them, as they are portrayed as fearless children. On some occasions, the parents can be seen clearly pushing the kids to do something they don’t want to, as seen in the video used in the preliminary analysis, where Calihan is forced to wake surf with his dad while screaming and crying, and in video 4, where he is forced to wear snorkel gear and to go underwater. Nevertheless, in multiple occasions the parents can be seen respecting the kid’s will to not do certain activities. Ultimately, it can be argued that the dynamics between the parents and the children revolve exclusively around the children’s performance.

### **6.3. Overall Analysis**

After independently analysing both the qualitative and quantitative data collected, it is critical to combine both results, in order to obtain an overview of the family’s online practices. By watching the Gee family’s videos, it is possible to establish that their narratives heavily rely on the achievements of the kids and their apparent fearlessness, as they are exposed to situations of increased risk. Therefore, it can be argued that the promotion of spectacularity is used to attract more viewers. By sensationalizing the titles of the videos, manipulating their thumbnails and deliberately promote the involvement of their children in extraordinary situations, Garret and Jessica build their business by capitalizing on their viewers’ attention, as described by Goldhaber in his account of an attention economy.

The family presents itself as “just your average family” in the introduction included in some videos. By portraying themselves as average, they aim to make their content relatable, and therefore, achieve a certain type of public intimacy, as their apparently mundane lives are made public. As one sorts the videos by date it is fairly easy to perceive the evolution within video production skills, both in video quality and video editing. This investment can be justified by the fact that YouTube is increasingly becoming important



as not only a revenue source but also a platform to promote their other projects. Another visible change made throughout the years, is the heightened involvement of the children in the videos, as in more recent content the children take on a more active role in the videos, by starring in them but also narrating them. This increased responsibility attributed to the children, can be paired with the fact that most of the footage already revolves around them, as they can be seen playing, swimming and interacting with their parents and each other. These two aspects, combined with the fact that 48% of the video titles analysed contain vocabulary that indicate the presence of the children in the videos, show just how important the kids are for the family's business. Furthermore, one can classify the children's role as 'playbour', as there is no strict distinction between play hours and work hours, and no labour contracts are signed. Ultimately, it is fair to argue that their participation in the videos can be conceptualized as a form of digital child labour. Nevertheless, as engaging in these activities is not optional for the kids, one can go even further and attribute an exploitive character to their participation. This scenario can constitute a breach of the children's rights, as UNICEF proclaims that "children have the right to be protected from all (...) kinds of exploitation" and from any type of "harmful work" (n.d., the children's version section). Moreover, by not being paid for the work performed, the parents can be accused of actively using them to generate surplus value. Even if not recording, editing and uploading the videos themselves, it still can be argued that the Gee children are the main contributors to the family's business, as they are forced to renounce their privacy in order to generate content for the family's business. This lack of privacy is embodied to an extreme in situations where the children are exposed naked, and in vulnerable situations both emotionally and physically. Moreover, by including the children in the content produced since they are babies, the parents are actively contributing to the creation of their children's digital footprints. In the case of Calihan, the youngest member of the family, this online presence was established both before birth by the sharing of ultrasound images and during birth, as the family recorded the important occasion (The Bucket List Family, 2018b).

## 7. Concluding Discussion

When returning to the initial proposed research questions, one can use the knowledge acquired through the analysis to better answer them. Regarding the first question, ‘how and to what extent are YouTube family vloggers using their children as labour for the ‘family business’?’, one can conclude that children are in fact central figures in the content uploaded by their parents, as 48% of the video titles include links the video back to them. Furthermore, while watching the videos, it is clear that the narratives shared by the family, are based upon the children’s performance, behaviours and interactions. In some cases, it becomes apparent that the children’s image is used to capitalize the family’s brand, either by being instrumentalized as promoters for the sale of family merchandise or simply by being responsible for capturing the viewer’s attention with their fearlessness.

The second question, ‘how can these new practices be analysed in the light of children’s rights?’, involves the conceptualization of these practices using a rights-based approach. As previously mentioned in the analysis of the results, it is possible to argue that by being central figures in the content, they can be perceived as the main source of interest for viewers, making them essential contributors to the revenue generated and possibly qualifying them as active economic actors. Besides establishing that the children’s performances are a type of digital labour, it is also possible to argue that family vlogging is breaching children’s rights. This breach can be justified by that fact that children are not included in decisions regarding their own future, by the lack of explicit consent for recording and sharing footage where they are included, by arguing that their parents are instrumentalizing them for views and by the possibly devastating and harmful loss of their privacy.

Based on the results obtained, one can conclude that children are the main participants in family vlogging, both by being present in almost half of the video titles and also by being present in the videos themselves. Sensationalistic approaches are adopted by the parents as a strategy to increase the channel’s popularity. This strategy seems to be working, as the five analysed videos have a staggering 40,8 million views when combined. This considerable exposure not only robs the minors from their privacy, but it also does so without their explicit consent, leaving them extremely vulnerable.

While building on concepts that have already been developed by the scientific community, the current thesis explores a fairly recent phenomenon. As multiple studies have been conducted on YouTube, there is still a gap of research concerning family vlogging. Some studies give evidence of the negative effects that YouTube and family vlogging can have on children, urging lawmakers to act on behalf of the minors. Nevertheless, by contextualizing these practices in the light of children's rights, this thesis provides a solid rights-based framework to the study of this phenomenon. By doing so, it might act as a steppingstone to future policy making. However, before this can happen more studies need to be conducted, since limitations are a common denominator in all research.

As for the current thesis, one can argue that the use of a case study approach might lead to a limited sample. By focusing on only one specimen, the results of this research can only be recognized as indicators and not as universal truths. Furthermore, by conducting a qualitative analysis, the subjectiveness of the results obtained might present challenges to possible replications of the study.

Therefore, future studies could benefit from the use of a bigger and more varied sample, namely by focusing on more than one channel. Additionally, the possibility of carrying-out focus groups could provide beneficial outcomes to the study, by gathering important feedback from a selected audience and by analysing their reactions and thoughts regarding family vlogging practices. Eventually, being able to interview the children involved in this type of content would be the ideal scenario, as it would allow them a chance to share their side of the story. However, this type of interviews could prove both hard to obtain and ethically challenging to conduct, as we are dealing with minors. Lastly, and even if addressed in this thesis, the complexity and current relevance of the new economic reality established under the concept of 'surveillance capitalism', justify further research on this topic.

To conclude, one can highlight the importance of the current thesis, by arguing that the results obtained have real and tangible benefits to society, as they expose the structures of digital labour behind family vlogging. Perhaps, by acknowledging that these children are workers for their families' businesses, society becomes more aware of the need to protect them.

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## 9. Appendixes

Appendix 1: Table of video titles (quantitative analysis)

| <b>Title of the Video</b>                                                                                   | <b>Date of Upload</b> |
|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------|
| <b>5 YR OLD Scuba Dives with GREAT WHITE SHARKS in Mexico!!</b>                                             | 25/11/2019            |
| <b>5 YR OLD FREE DIVES THE BLUE HOLE!! /// WEEK 105 : Great Blue Hole, Belize</b>                           | 29/04/2018            |
| <b>Kids Swimming with Sharks!! /// WEEK 107 : Bahamas</b>                                                   | 13/05/2018            |
| <b>Teaching Our 2 YR OLD BABY to Swim Underwater</b>                                                        | 22/03/2020            |
| <b>BABY SWIM LESSONS - The Ultimate Routine to Help Our 2 YR OLD Swim and Deep Dive Underwater</b>          | 06/09/2020            |
| <b>THE DEEPEST BATH TUB IN THE WORLD!</b>                                                                   | 12/05/2019            |
| <b>BIRTH STORY!! Welcome Baby Boy, Calihan Gee!! /// WEEK 101 : Utah</b>                                    | 01/04/2018            |
| <b>KIDS LEARN TO SWIM! Inspiration from Around the World! Kids and Baby Swim Lessons Underwater Routine</b> | 13/09/2020            |
| <b>5 YR OLD Manilla TOUCHED the BOTTOM OF THE OCEAN!!</b>                                                   | 26/01/2020            |
| <b>Dad Saves His Little Girl! Surf and Swim Lessons Routine in Hawaii.</b>                                  | 07/02/2021            |
| <b>Little Brother SAVES Big Sister! Surf and Swim Lessons Routine in Hawaii.</b>                            | 06/12/2020            |
| <b>Little Kids Swimming with BIG WHALES!! /// Ultimate Tonga Bucket List Adventure!!</b>                    | 15/09/2019            |
| <b>BABY SWIM LESSONS IN THE MALDIVES</b>                                                                    | 26/09/2021            |
| <b>SHAVING OUR HAIR with the Monks of Bhutan!!</b>                                                          | 04/11/2018            |
| <b>WHERE You Want Your BIRTHDAY??!! FREEDIVING in the DEEPEST Pool!! /// WEEK 87 : Belgium</b>              | 12/11/2017            |
| <b>LEARN TO RIDE A BIKE in the Maldives - Soneva Fushi</b>                                                  | 25/08/2019            |

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|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------|
| <b>OUR LAST VLOG as a Full-Time Traveling Family :( /// WEEK 121 : Tonga</b>                                | 12/08/2018 |
| <b>KIDS Swimming with SHARKS in Tahiti!! ARE THEY NICE??</b>                                                | 17/06/2019 |
| <b>CRAZY WATER SLIDE CRUISE SHIP!! On Board The Aida Perla Maiden Voyage!!</b>                              | 09/07/2017 |
| <b>7 Years - Lukas Graham - Cover for Dorothy Gee Bucket List Birthday</b>                                  | 08/11/2020 |
| <b>WE ARE QUITTING EVERYTHING.. And We are Joining the Circus!! /// WEEK 112 : Dominican Republic</b>       | 10/06/201  |
| <b>6 YR OLD Dorothy FREE DIVES DEEP into the Ocean of Aitutaki!!</b>                                        | 30/06/2019 |
| <b>SURF SAFETY LESSONS for KIDS : Deep Dive Routine. Dad Saves Manilla in Sayulita, Mexico.</b>             | 11/04/2021 |
| <b>2 MINUTES Around the World! Our Family Journey with 3 Kids. Underwater Adventures! Sharks! and More!</b> | 19/04/2020 |
| <b>Little Girl Surfs with Big Shark in Hawaii</b>                                                           | 17/01/2021 |
| <b>OUR WEDDING VIDEO (We got RE-married for our 10yr Anniversary)</b>                                       | 05/05/2019 |
| <b>100 WEEKS of Full-Time Travel and Now..A BABY BOY!!</b>                                                  | 11/02/2018 |
| <b>CHRISTMAS IN HAWAII OR CANADA??</b>                                                                      | 31/12/2018 |
| <b>SMALL BITE! 5 YR OLD Free Dives with WILD SEA LIONS in AUSTRALIA!</b>                                    | 05/07/2020 |
| <b>FAMILY SURF TRIP TO SAYULITA, MEXICO! PART 2 of 3 /// Kids Deep Dive, Baby Sea Turtles and Waterfall</b> | 04/04/2021 |
| <b>Travel With Kids : WHY WE DO IT</b>                                                                      | 20/08/2018 |
| <b>OUR 1ST VLOG!! Let's Sell Everything for an Adventure Around the World!! /// WEEK 1 : Provo, Utah</b>    | 09/08/2015 |
| <b>WE SUPRISED OUR KIDS WITH A DISNEY CRUISE!!</b>                                                          | 17/03/2019 |
| <b>BABY SWIM LESSONS in the DEEP END - The Ultimate Routine with the Big Kids!</b>                          | 13/12/2020 |
| <b>5 YR Old Dives with the Biggest Shark in the World</b>                                                   | 12/07/2020 |

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|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------|
| <b>BABY CALI SHARED HIS BIRTHDAY WISH!! (IM NOT CRYING!!)</b>                                             | 09/02/2020 |
| <b>5 YR OLD Jumps Out of Helicopter Into Ocean! BEST TOURS OF HAWAII</b>                                  | 16/12/2019 |
| <b>HOUSE TOUR : How We Found Our Home in Hawaii</b>                                                       | 20/01/2019 |
| <b>JUMPING INTO GLACIER COLD WATER IN PATAGONIA, CHILE!!</b>                                              | 14/04/2019 |
| <b>INDIA WITH KIDS? INCREDIBLE!! /// WEEK 120 : India</b>                                                 | 05/08/2018 |
| <b>Mom is Emergency Lifted by Helicopter to the Hospital. Heli Ski Accident in Utah.</b>                  | 02/05/2021 |
| <b>WE FOUND REAL MERMAIDS!! Indonesia with Julianne Hough, Nina Dobrev, and friends!!</b>                 | 16/12/2018 |
| <b>The PERFECT PLACE?? Cook Islands! Part 1 of 2</b>                                                      | 24/06/2019 |
| <b>STUCK OR SAFE?? Our Family Quarantine at Home in Hawaii During Coronavirus Pandemic of Covid-19.</b>   | 02/08/2020 |
| <b>HURRICANE LANE OUR 1ST WEEK HOME IN HAWAII!?! </b>                                                     | 26/08/2018 |
| <b>BABY SURF AND SWIM LESSONS. 3 Yr Old Cali Deep Dive Routine in Hawaii.</b>                             | 22/02/2021 |
| <b>ONLY IN AUSTRALIA : WILD BABY Kangaroos ON THE BEACH with our Kids!!</b>                               | 24/05/2020 |
| <b>NO CAGE - Diving With TIGER SHARKS!! /// WEEK 108 : Tiger Shark Beach</b>                              | 14/05/2018 |
| <b>HAVE YOU HEARD OF BHUTAN??! /// The Bucket List Family</b>                                             | 28/10/2018 |
| <b>Walter Mitty Inspired Adventures in Iceland!! And Manilla's Potty Surprise!! /// WEEK 76 : Iceland</b> | 16/07/2017 |
| <b>I CRIED WHEN I SAW WHAT THIS MOMMA BEAR DID FOR HER BABIES</b>                                         | 25/10/2020 |
| <b>Dad Saves His Little Girl! Ski Lessons and Snowboard Routine for Kids and Baby. 8, 6, 3 yrs old.</b>   | 25/04/2021 |
| <b>Who is The Bucket List Family??</b>                                                                    | 14/01/2019 |

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|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------|
| <b>HOW WE GOT STARTED AS A FULL-TIME TRAVELING FAMILY<br/>  Speech at BYU</b>                                   | 25/02/2018 |
| <b>STUCK IN A DUST STORM!! 14 Days in Australia during the<br/>Pandemic w Kids, Shark Dives, and Manta Rays</b> | 20/07/2020 |
| <b>TRUE STORY - Sold to Snapchat for \$54 Million.. /// PART 1<br/>of 2</b>                                     | 03/11/2019 |
| <b>The SURPRISE That Made Dorothy CRY! Mermaids, the<br/>Deepest Bathtub, and Backyard Turtles!</b>             | 20/10/2019 |
| <b>OUR 2 BIG SURPRISES !! /// WEEK 114</b>                                                                      | 24/06/2018 |
| <b>HOW WE LEARNED TO SURF! Surf School Part 2. The<br/>Ultimate Surf Routine in Hawaii. 7 and 5 yrs old.</b>    | 04/10/2020 |
| <b>TOOTH PULLED ON MY BIRTHDAY!?! + Hollywood and Bday<br/>Party!</b>                                           | 17/11/2019 |
| <b>TEACHING KIDS TO HOLD THEIR BREATH UNDERWATER<br/>During Quarantine Coronavirus Pandemic of Covid-19</b>     | 09/08/2020 |
| <b>THE 2 MOST BUCKET LIST THINGS TO DO IN ZANZIBAR.<br/>Ultimate African Adventures!</b>                        | 29/07/2019 |
| <b>CHRISTMAS MORNING SNOWED IN! Family Travel Home<br/>and Polar Dip Challenge.</b>                             | 27/12/2021 |
| <b>BREAKFAST at The GIRAFFE MANOR!! ELEPHANTS and<br/>MORE!! /// WEEK 118 : Kenya</b>                           | 22/07/2018 |
| <b>GENDER REVEAL!! BABY BOY or BABY GIRL??</b>                                                                  | 22/10/2017 |
| <b>OUR WORST FLIGHT EVER??!</b>                                                                                 | 18/11/2018 |
| <b>FACING OUR GREATEST FEARS in NEW ZEALAND!!</b>                                                               | 04/02/2019 |
| <b>Asked Our 3 Kids WHY THEY LOVE MOMMY?? Their<br/>Answer's WONT Shock You ;) Mothers Day 2020</b>             | 10/05/2020 |
| <b>Kids Surfing in SHARK Waters of Australia</b>                                                                | 07/06/2020 |
| <b>MOM BROKE THE CHRISTMAS TREE!! SHE'S THE GRINCH!!</b>                                                        | 08/12/2019 |
| <b>ALL GOOD THINGS MUST COME TO AN END</b>                                                                      | 06/10/2019 |
| <b>BABY CALI POOPED IN THE POOL??!?</b>                                                                         | 02/02/2020 |

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|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------|
| <b>KIDS ZIPLINE ALONE. DAD IS TOO SCARED.</b>                                                               | 15/08/2021 |
| <b>Dorothy's SURPRISE Trip to SEATTLE to See Her BESTIE Claire Crosby! REUNITED Since Walt Disney World</b> | 10/01/2021 |
| <b>MERMAIDS ARE REAL!! Swimming with Dolphins, Manta Rays, and SHARKS!! /// WEEK 70 : Kona, Hawaii</b>      | 21/05/2017 |
| <b>1ST DAY OF SURF SCHOOL Part 1 with 7 YR Old Dorothy and 5 YR Old Manilla. The Ultimate Surf Routine.</b> | 28/09/2020 |
| <b>HAPPY BIRTHDAY MANILLA!! 4 YEARS OLD!!</b>                                                               | 16/09/2018 |
| <b>FAMILY SURF TRIP TO SAYULITA, MEXICO! PART 1 of 3 /// Kids Travel, Food, Surf Routine</b>                | 29/03/2021 |
| <b>EPIC Birthday Party and Helicopter Surprise for 3 YR OLD "Baby" Cali.</b>                                | 31/01/2021 |
| <b>FULL TOUR of the CINDERELLA CASTLE SUITE!! Behind the Scenes of 30 Days at Walt Disney World</b>         | 24/09/2017 |
| <b>CAN YOU SEABOB WITH DOLPHINS?? Free Diving the Deep Blue Sea!!</b>                                       | 13/10/2019 |
| <b>PART 2 : Mom is Emergency Saved by Helicopter to the Hospital. Torn ACL Surgery in Utah.</b>             | 09/05/2021 |
| <b>HALLOWEEN AT DISNEYLAND!! - The Bucket List Family</b>                                                   | 14/10/2018 |
| <b>4 YEAR JOURNEY AROUND THE WORLD in 4 MINUTES</b>                                                         | 11/08/2019 |
| <b>DADDY + DAUGHTER SHARE THE SAME BIRTHDAY!!</b>                                                           | 11/11/2018 |
| <b>AIRPORT CLOSED. THE PLANE IS TURNING AROUND!</b>                                                         | 25/03/2019 |
| <b>BAD IDEA? Dance Battle with Swimsuit Models</b>                                                          | 17/02/2020 |
| <b>The BEST and the WORST of Cape Town. Sharks, Penguins, and Robbers!! /// WEEK 74 : Cape Town</b>         | 26/06/2017 |
| <b>From AFRICA to FIJI with 3 Kids!! /// WEEK 119 : Fiji</b>                                                | 29/07/2018 |
| <b>Full-Time Traveling Family - Introducing The Bucket List Family</b>                                      | 26/03/2017 |
| <b>5 YR OLD FREE DIVES DEEP TO FIND THE HIDDEN MICKEY UNDERWATER!! Walt Disney World + Disney Cruise!</b>   | 08/03/2020 |



|                                                                                                     |            |
|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------|
| <b>WEDDING??! Haven't Dressed Up in 3 Years!!</b>                                                   | 03/09/2018 |
| <b>WHAT'S INSIDE?? Opening Presents from Santa Claus.<br/>Christmas Day Family Special.</b>         | 27/12/2020 |
| <b>The 3 BEST Ways to Experience the Maldives! /// WEEK 72 :<br/>Maldives</b>                       | 11/06/2017 |
| <b>His 1 AND ONLY Birthday Wish..</b>                                                               | 23/09/2019 |
| <b>BABY SURFING IN IDAHO?? Kids and Baby River and Wake<br/>Surfing!! Road Trip Summer Routine.</b> | 18/10/2020 |
| <b>I Married a Fijian Warrior!! Diving with Sharks - NO CAGE!!<br/>/// WEEK 62 : Fiji</b>           | 12/02/2017 |
| <b>We Stayed at EVERY Walt Disney World Resort! 30 Stays in<br/>30 days + 1!!</b>                   | 15/03/2020 |
| <b>African Safari with 5 Month Baby!! KID FRIENDLY?? ///<br/>WEEK 117 : Tanzania</b>                | 15/07/2018 |
| <b>BEST Resort at Walt Disney World?? See ALL 30 Resorts in<br/>30 Days!!</b>                       | 05/10/2017 |

Appendix 2: Table of frequencies (quantitative analysis)

| <b>Variables</b>                                   | <b>Frequency</b> |
|----------------------------------------------------|------------------|
| <b>Variable 01. 'Child/Children'</b>               | 0                |
| <b>Variable 02. 'Kid/Kids/Little Kids'</b>         | 22               |
| <b>Variable 03. 'Baby'</b>                         | 15               |
| <b>Variable 04. 'Boy/Little Boy'</b>               | 3                |
| <b>Variable 05. 'Girl/Little Girl'</b>             | 4                |
| <b>Variable 06. 'Age of the Child'</b>             | 16               |
| <b>Variable 07. 'Dorothy, Manilla and Calihan'</b> | 14               |